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Information on caliber (firearms)

Throughout this book, measurements are provided in US measurements and metric, except in the case of caliber.

In the muzzle-loading era, the gauge diameters, or calibers, of guns were often not standardized, so calibers are provided in both US and metric measurements for each weapon from this period. With the advent of the metallic cartridge, manufacturers provided specifications for caliber, which is expressed in either inches or millimeters only.

Calibers of shotgun are given by “gauge,” since this type of firearm is still identified using a form of measurement created in the 17th century, based on the number of balls which could be cast from a single pound of lead.